

The guidelines below were adopted for the Spring & Fall 2024 semesters. They will be assessed again after one year. As a result of the vote, all faculty teaching an SPA undergraduate course will need to include in their syllabi, or in a separate handout, either the long-form or short-form criteria attached for evaluating student work. Needless to say, faculty should not just distribute these agreed upon criteria but also use them as a guide when evaluating & grading student work. If you are teaching a 400/600 level class SPA would encourage to use these criteria but leaves it to your discretion.

Long-Form Grading criteria

- A** Excellent/outstanding: met or exceeded **the highest** expectations on all criteria for the assignment or course. Class assignments & final course grades in the A range will meet or exceed the highest expectations for such work. A-range student work may be outstanding or excellent in the clarity of its arguments, the application of analytical techniques in papers or assignments, the relevance & sensitivity of the evidence that students deploy, or in solving all or virtually all posed problems correctly. Papers & other written work in the A-range will generally manifest intellectual creativity, while also demonstrating attention to important prior works on the subject with careful & complete attributions (citations) & indicating with precision the importance of its focus & conclusions for our understanding of public affairs & its specific subject. Student work in the A-range will display elements of originality (ideas & perspectives not previously discussed in class) in the conception of its subject, in the evidence & reasoning it brings to bear on that subject, in the analytical techniques it employs, or in all of these. When appropriate, such work will also anticipate & respond to major objections to its position. To merit an A, a class assignment or final course grade should reflect student work that demonstrates high-level mastery of its subject, is well written, includes proper citations when relying on the ideas of others, develops its arguments in an orderly way, & presents its ideas clearly & crisply. Poor grammar & style, factually incorrect solutions or assertions, frequent unsupported assertions, or claims, & more than occasional misspellings have no place in class assignments or a semester of work meriting an A.
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- A-** Excellent (somewhat): met **very high** expectations on all criteria, or **the highest** expectations on all but one or two criteria for the assignment or course. The mark of A- should be given to class assignments or semester course grades that meet **very high** expectations on all criteria, or **the highest** expectations on all but one or two criteria discussed above.
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- B+** Good (very): met **high** expectations on all but one or two criteria for the assignment or course. A class assignment or final course grade in the B+ range should be awarded to less outstanding work that nonetheless meets expectations for the assignment or course at a high level. A well-written paper or case study which nonetheless yields few novel lessons of general import, or a good critical review that does not go beyond previous works on the subject would merit a grade in this range. Like the A-range class assignment or final semester grade, one in the B-range should be grounded in substantial work appropriate to its objectives, but the latter performance will fall short in some specific way(s) specified in the assignment or course expectations. A class assignment or final course grade in the B+ range should represent student work that demonstrates mastery of its subject to a high level, is clearly written & logically organized for effective communication of its ideas.
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- B** Good: met **standard** expectations all but one or two criteria for the assignment or course. A class assignment or final course grade in the B range should be awarded to less outstanding work that nonetheless meets expectations for the assignment or course at a **standard** level while also showing reasonable command of the material for the assignment or course. A well-written paper or case study which nonetheless yields few novel lessons of general import, or a good critical review that does not go beyond previous works on the subject would merit a grade in this range. Like the A-range class assignment or final semester grade, one in the B-range should be grounded in substantial work appropriate to its objectives, but the latter performance will fall short in some specific way(s) specified in the assignment or course expectations. A class assignment or final course grade in the B range should still represent student work that demonstrates mastery of its subject to a standard level, is clearly written & logically organized for effective communication of its ideas.
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- B-** Good (somewhat)/fair: met **standard** expectations on most criteria (>50%) for the assignment or course while also falling short on one or two significant criteria or on a number of less important criteria. A grade of B- is appropriate for well-conceived student work & overall performance that meets standard expectations on most criteria but nonetheless contains one or two significant flaws in execution, or a number of less important shortcomings. A class assignment or final course grade in the B- range should still represent student work that demonstrates reasonable mastery of its subject to a standard level.
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- C+** Satisfactory (very): met **minimum** expectations on all criteria for the assignment or course. A class assignment or final course grade in the C+ range represents student work that meets all of the minimum expectations for the assignment or course. Such work may be flawed in some ways, such as the inadequacy of its research, lack of engagement with (or proper attribution of) significant prior works, the logic of its arguments may be faulty, the conclusions or findings may not be explored adequately, calculations may be incorrectly
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conducted, explanations may be incomplete or convoluted, or the writing may be mediocre & contain numerous grammatical, construction, & spelling errors. An informative case study that offers little analysis, or a review of a body of literature that generally gets things right but does little with the ideas therein, or a semester performance that meets only the minimum expectations on all criteria for the course should be given a grade in the C+ range.

C Satisfactory: met minimum expectations on most criteria (>50%) for the assignment or course while falling short in some ways.

For undergraduates, a grade of C or above is required to receive major, minor, or certificate course credit.

A class assignment or final course grade in the C range represents student work that meets most of the minimum expectations for the assignment or course. Such work may be flawed in some ways, such as the inadequacy of its research, lack of engagement with (or proper attribution of) significant prior works, the logic of its arguments may be faulty, the conclusions or findings may not be explored adequately, calculations may be incorrectly conducted, explanations may be incomplete or convoluted, or the writing may be mediocre & contain numerous grammatical, construction, & spelling errors. An informative case study that offers little analysis, or a review of a body of literature that generally gets things right but does little with the ideas therein, or a semester performance that meets only the minimum expectations on most, but not all, criteria for the course should be given a grade in the C range.

C- Satisfactory (somewhat): fell short of meeting minimum expectations on most criteria (>50%) for the assignment or course.

For undergraduates, a grade of C- is sufficient to receive elective course credit.

A grade in the C- range should be given to class assignments or a semester performance that falls short of meeting the minimum expectations on most (more than half) of the criteria for the assignment or course.

D

Poor: fell short of meeting **minimum** expectations on most criteria for the assignment or course.

For undergraduates, a grade of D or above is required to receive elective course credit.

To merit the grade of D, a class assignment must consider a non-trivial subject in public affairs & must show evidence that the writer has some knowledge about that subject. Beyond that little can be said in praise of a paper or class assignment meriting a D, which is the lowest passing grade reserved for works that fall short of meeting minimum expectations on most criteria for the assignment. Likewise, a final course grade in the D range represents student performance that largely falls short of meeting minimum expectations on most criteria for the course.

F Academic failing; very poor performance.

A class assignment or overall semester performance that does not meet the minimum requirements for the grade of D should be given an F. This is a very poor performance that fails to satisfy academic requirements.

Short-Form Grading criteria

A Excellent/outstanding: met or exceeded **the highest** expectations on all criteria for the assignment or course.

A- Excellent (somewhat): met **very high** expectations on all criteria, or **the highest** expectations on all but one or two criteria for the assignment or course.

B+ Good (very): met **high** expectations on all but one or two criteria for the assignment or course.

B Good: met **standard** expectations all but one or two criteria for the assignment or course.

B- Good (somewhat)/fair: met **standard** expectations on most criteria (>50%) for the assignment or course while also falling short on one or two significant criteria or on a number of less important criteria.

C+ Satisfactory (very): met **minimum** expectations on all criteria for the assignment or course.

C Satisfactory: met minimum expectations on most criteria (>50%) for the assignment or course while falling short in some ways. For undergraduates, a grade of C or above is required to receive major, minor, or certificate course credit.

C- Satisfactory (somewhat): fell short of meeting minimum expectations on most criteria (>50%) for the assignment or course. For undergraduates, a grade of C- is sufficient to receive elective course credit.

D Poor: fell short of meeting **minimum** expectations on most criteria for the assignment or course. For undergraduates, a grade of D or above is required to receive elective course credit.

F Academic failing; very poor performance.
